

1. Welcome and Handbook Purpose

Employee Handbook | Northstar Digital Solutions Pvt. Ltd. | Fictional training document

About Northstar Digital Solutions

Northstar Digital Solutions Pvt. Ltd. is a fictional technology and business services company created for training and demonstration purposes. The company provides software engineering, data, automation, customer experience, and consulting services to clients. This Employee Handbook explains the workplace policies employees are expected to understand during their employment. It is intended to give employees one consistent reference for common questions about work schedules, leave, conduct, referrals, performance, compensation practices, information security, and separation from the company.

How to use this handbook

Employees should first refer to this handbook when they have a routine policy question. Managers and the People Operations team may provide additional guidance where a situation requires interpretation. The handbook does not create an employment contract and may be updated as business needs or applicable rules change. Where a written employment agreement or applicable law provides a different requirement, that document or law takes precedence.

Core principles

Northstar expects employees to act with integrity, respect colleagues, protect company and client information, communicate early when problems arise, and take ownership of assigned work. Employees should ask for clarification rather than make assumptions when a policy or instruction is unclear. Retaliation against an employee who raises a genuine workplace concern in good faith is not permitted.

2. Employment Categories and Probation

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Employment categories

Employees may be classified as full-time, part-time, fixed-term, intern, consultant, or other categories specified in their engagement documents. Full-time employees normally work the standard schedule described in this handbook. Interns and fixed-term employees follow the schedule and benefits stated in their individual letters unless a policy specifically says otherwise.

Probation period

New full-time employees normally complete a probation period of 90 calendar days from their joining date. During probation, managers review attendance, quality of work, communication, learning progress, reliability, and role fit. The company may confirm employment at the end of probation, extend probation where additional observation is needed, or take another action permitted by the employee's agreement and applicable requirements.

Confirmation

Successful completion of probation is communicated in writing by People Operations. Completion of 90 days by itself should not be treated as confirmation unless the employee has received the relevant communication. Employees are encouraged to discuss performance expectations with their manager throughout probation rather than waiting for the final review.

3. Working Hours and Attendance

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Standard working schedule

The standard full-time working schedule is Monday through Friday, 9:30 a.m. to 6:30 p.m., including a one-hour meal and rest break. A team may operate different hours because of client coverage or project requirements. Any recurring change to an employee's schedule should be communicated by the manager. Employees working remotely remain responsible for being available during their agreed working hours.

Attendance

Employees should begin work on time and remain reasonably reachable during scheduled hours. If an employee expects to be late or unavailable, they should notify their manager as early as practical. Repeated unexplained lateness, absence, or failure to communicate may be addressed through the performance or disciplinary process.

Timesheets

Teams that use timesheets must record working time accurately and submit entries by the stated deadline. Employees must not knowingly enter false hours, record time for another person, or ask another employee to alter time records inaccurately. Questions about project codes or billable time should be raised with the manager before submission.

4. Remote and Hybrid Work

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Remote work expectations

Employees approved for remote work must maintain a suitable working environment, dependable internet access, and reasonable availability during agreed working hours. Remote work does not change performance expectations, confidentiality duties, security requirements, or attendance responsibilities. Employees should join scheduled meetings on time and communicate when connectivity problems materially affect their work.

Working location

An employee should not permanently change their primary working location or work from another country without written approval. Temporary location changes may require approval because of client, tax, security, insurance, or legal considerations. Company equipment must be protected during travel and should not be left unattended in public locations.

Office attendance

Where a role follows a hybrid arrangement, the manager may identify collaboration days or client-driven office requirements. Employees should plan attendance accordingly. Exceptions for a specific day may be discussed with the manager, but repeated changes to an agreed hybrid pattern should be formally reviewed.

5. Annual Leave Policy

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Annual leave entitlement

Eligible full-time employees receive 18 days of paid annual leave for each completed year of service. Leave is credited according to the company's leave administration schedule and may be prorated for employees who join during the year. Annual leave is intended for rest, personal commitments, and planned time away from work.

Requesting annual leave

Employees should submit planned annual leave through the designated leave system at least five working days in advance whenever reasonably possible. Approval depends on project deadlines, minimum team coverage, previously approved leave, and business needs. Employees should not make non-refundable travel commitments before obtaining approval.

Carry forward

A maximum of five unused annual leave days may be carried into the next calendar year. Carried leave should normally be used by 31 March of the following year; unused carried leave expires after that date unless People Operations confirms an exception in writing. Employees and managers are encouraged to plan leave throughout the year rather than accumulate large balances.

6. Sick Leave and Emergency Absence

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Sick leave

Eligible full-time employees receive 8 days of paid sick leave per calendar year. Sick leave may be used when an employee is unwell or requires time away for a health-related reason covered by company policy. Employees should inform their manager as early as practical when they cannot work.

Documentation

For a continuous sickness absence of three or more working days, the company may request reasonable supporting documentation where permitted. The purpose is to administer leave consistently, not to require employees to disclose unnecessary medical details. People Operations should handle any sensitive documentation confidentially.

Emergency absence

Unexpected personal emergencies should be communicated to the manager as soon as practical. Depending on the circumstances and available leave balance, the absence may be recorded as annual leave, sick leave where applicable, unpaid leave, or another approved category. Employees should update their manager if the expected return date changes.

7. Unpaid Leave and Loss of Pay

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When unpaid leave applies

Unpaid leave, also called loss of pay or LOP for payroll purposes, may apply when an employee has no applicable paid leave balance, chooses an unpaid absence with approval, or has an absence that is not eligible for paid leave. Employees should obtain approval wherever the absence can be planned in advance.

Salary deduction method

For this handbook's simplified payroll policy, loss-of-pay deductions are calculated using a 30-day payroll month. The employee's gross monthly salary is calculated as annual gross salary divided by 12. The daily salary rate is gross monthly salary divided by 30. The LOP deduction equals the daily salary rate multiplied by the number of unpaid leave days. Estimated payable gross salary for the month equals gross monthly salary minus the LOP deduction.

Example

If an employee's annual gross salary is INR 1,200,000, the gross monthly salary is INR 100,000. The 30-day daily rate is approximately INR 3,333.33. If the employee has two approved unpaid leave days, the estimated LOP deduction is approximately INR 6,666.67 and the estimated payable gross salary is approximately INR 93,333.33. This example excludes tax, provident fund, benefits, bonuses, reimbursements, and other payroll adjustments.

8. Employee Referral Program

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Purpose

The Employee Referral Program encourages employees to recommend suitable candidates for open roles. A referral should be submitted through the designated referral channel before the candidate is formally entered into the recruitment process. Employees should provide accurate information and should not promise employment, compensation, or selection outcomes to a candidate.

Eligibility and referral bonus

Most active employees may submit referrals, except employees directly responsible for the hiring decision for that vacancy and members of the recruiting team where a conflict exists. For eligible roles, the standard referral bonus is INR 20,000. The bonus becomes payable after the referred candidate completes 90 calendar days of continuous employment and the referring employee remains actively employed on the payment processing date.

Duplicate referrals and payment

If the same candidate is referred by more than one employee, the first valid referral recorded in the recruitment system is normally recognized. Referral bonuses are processed through payroll and may be subject to applicable deductions. Some senior, temporary, campus, confidential, or specialist roles may have a different bonus or may be excluded; any exception will be stated in the job referral notice.

9. Recruitment and Internal Opportunities

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Fair recruitment

Hiring decisions should be based on job-related qualifications, experience, skills, interview evidence, role requirements, and legitimate business needs. Employees involved in hiring must avoid conflicts of interest and must protect candidate information. A referral does not guarantee an interview or employment offer.

Internal applications

Employees may apply for internally advertised roles when they meet the stated eligibility requirements. As a general guideline, an employee should have completed at least six months in their current role before requesting an internal transfer, unless the current manager and People Operations approve an exception.

Candidate confidentiality

Interview notes, resumes, compensation discussions, and hiring decisions are confidential business information. Employees should not share them with people who do not require access for the recruitment process.

10. Performance Management

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Performance expectations

Employees are expected to understand their responsibilities, agreed objectives, quality standards, and deadlines. Managers should provide ongoing feedback and employees should raise blockers early. Performance is evaluated using relevant evidence such as work quality, reliability, collaboration, customer impact, problem solving, learning, and delivery against agreed goals.

Review cycle

Northstar normally conducts a formal performance review twice each year, supported by regular manager check-ins. A review discussion should cover achievements, areas for development, goals for the next period, and support required from the manager or company.

Performance improvement

When performance falls materially below expectations, the manager may provide documented feedback and a reasonable improvement plan. The plan may define specific expectations, support, checkpoints, and a review period. The purpose is to make expectations clear and provide an opportunity for improvement; serious conduct matters may follow a separate process.

11. Compensation and Payroll

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Salary payments

Regular monthly salary is normally processed on the last working day of each month, subject to payroll cut-off dates and banking processing. Employees are responsible for keeping their bank and required payroll information current. Payroll questions should be raised promptly with People Operations or the designated payroll contact.

Gross salary and deductions

An employee's offer or compensation letter states the applicable compensation structure. Gross salary is not the same as final take-home pay. Statutory deductions, taxes, benefits, loss-of-pay deductions, recoveries, or other authorized adjustments may affect the final amount credited to the employee.

Salary estimator limitation

Any internal salary estimator provided with this handbook is for demonstration and approximate gross-pay calculations only. It should not be treated as an official payslip or tax calculation. Official payroll records and payslips remain the authoritative source for actual salary payments.

12. Expense Reimbursement

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Business expenses

Reasonable and necessary business expenses may be reimbursed when they are incurred for an approved company purpose and comply with the applicable expense rules. Employees should seek approval before making unusual or high-value purchases on behalf of the company.

Submission deadline

Expense claims should normally be submitted within 30 calendar days of the expense date and should include a receipt or other acceptable supporting evidence. The claim should identify the business purpose, date, amount, and relevant project or cost center where required.

Non-reimbursable expenses

Personal purchases, fines, penalties caused by personal misconduct, unsupported expenses without a reasonable explanation, and expenses outside policy limits may be rejected. When a receipt is genuinely unavailable, the employee should contact the approver rather than fabricate or alter documentation.

13. Business Travel

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Travel approval

Business travel must be approved before booking unless an emergency exception applies. Employees should use the company's designated booking process where available and select reasonable travel options consistent with business requirements and safety.

Travel conduct

Employees travelling for work continue to represent the company and are expected to follow workplace conduct, confidentiality, information security, and expense policies. Company devices and documents should be secured throughout the trip.

Changes and cancellations

Employees should promptly update the manager or travel coordinator if business travel changes. Refundable or flexible options should be used when required by the applicable travel rules. Personal extensions to a business trip require approval where they affect cost, insurance, working time, or company arrangements.

14. Information Security

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Protecting information

Employees must protect company, employee, candidate, client, and partner information according to its sensitivity. Confidential information should be accessed only for legitimate work purposes and shared only with authorized people. Employees should use approved systems for storing and transmitting company information.

Passwords and credentials

Passwords, API keys, access tokens, multi-factor authentication codes, and other credentials must not be committed to source code, posted in chat channels, or shared with unauthorized people. Development secrets should be stored using approved environment variables or secret-management systems. Suspected credential exposure must be reported promptly.

Security incidents

Lost devices, suspicious login activity, phishing attempts, accidental data disclosure, malware warnings, and other suspected security incidents should be reported through the designated security channel as soon as possible. Employees should preserve relevant evidence and avoid taking actions that could make investigation more difficult.

15. Acceptable Use of Technology

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Company systems

Company devices, accounts, networks, and software are primarily provided for legitimate business use. Limited personal use may be permitted when it is lawful, reasonable, secure, and does not interfere with work or create material cost or risk.

Prohibited activity

Employees must not use company systems to intentionally access unlawful content, harass others, bypass security controls, install unauthorized malicious software, conduct unauthorized surveillance, or disclose confidential information. Attempts to gain access to systems or data without authorization are prohibited.

Software and AI tools

Employees should use approved software and AI services for company work. Confidential or client information must not be entered into an unapproved external AI service. AI-generated output should be reviewed by a responsible employee before it is relied upon for business decisions, customer communications, code, or formal documentation.

16. Confidentiality and Intellectual Property

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Confidential information

Confidential information includes non-public business plans, client information, source code, credentials, financial information, pricing, employee information, candidate records, contracts, designs, research, and other information identified or reasonably understood as confidential. Confidentiality obligations continue after employment where required by agreement or law.

Work product

Work created by an employee within the scope of employment or using company resources may be subject to the intellectual property terms in the employee's agreement and applicable law. Employees should maintain appropriate records and use company-approved repositories for work product.

External sharing

Employees should obtain authorization before publishing or presenting non-public company work externally. Open-source contributions, conference talks, portfolio examples, and public demonstrations must not expose confidential information, personal data, client materials, credentials, or proprietary code.

17. Workplace Conduct and Respect

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Professional conduct

Employees are expected to communicate respectfully and contribute to a workplace where people can perform their work without harassment, intimidation, bullying, or discriminatory treatment. Disagreements should focus on work issues rather than personal attacks.

Raising concerns

Employees who experience or observe inappropriate workplace conduct may raise the concern with their manager, People Operations, or another designated reporting channel. A manager who receives a serious concern should escalate it appropriately rather than attempting to conceal or informally dismiss it.

Good-faith reporting

The company prohibits retaliation against employees who make a good-faith report, participate honestly in an investigation, or seek guidance about a workplace concern. Knowingly making a deliberately false allegation may itself be addressed as misconduct.

18. Learning and Development

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Development

Employees are encouraged to maintain skills relevant to their role and discuss development goals with their manager. Learning may include project experience, mentoring, internal sessions, external courses, certifications, reading, experimentation, and structured training.

Training approval

Company-funded external training generally requires manager approval before registration or payment. Approval may consider relevance to the role, cost, workload, budget, and expected business value. Employees should follow any reimbursement or repayment terms communicated for a specific program.

Knowledge sharing

Employees who attend company-funded learning programs may be asked to share useful takeaways with their team. Internal knowledge sharing should respect copyright, licensing, client confidentiality, and restrictions on redistributing third-party course materials.

19. Disciplinary Process

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Policy concerns

Where an employee may have violated a workplace policy or reasonable instruction, the company may review the available facts before deciding on action. The response should consider the nature and seriousness of the issue, available evidence, prior guidance, impact, and applicable requirements.

Possible actions

Depending on the circumstances, actions may include coaching, documented feedback, a warning, an improvement plan, suspension where appropriate, or termination in serious cases. Not every situation follows identical steps, particularly where serious misconduct or legal obligations require a different response.

Employee response

Employees should have a reasonable opportunity to provide relevant information during a review where appropriate. Employees must cooperate honestly with legitimate workplace investigations and must not destroy, alter, or fabricate relevant records.

20. Resignation, Notice and Exit

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Notice period

Unless an employee's individual employment agreement states otherwise, the standard notice period for confirmed full-time employees is 30 calendar days. Employees on probation normally have a 15-calendar-day notice period. The applicable employment agreement remains the authoritative source if it specifies a different period.

Resignation process

Employees should submit resignation in writing to their manager and People Operations. The company will confirm the expected last working day after reviewing the applicable notice period, approved leave, transition requirements, and any mutually agreed changes.

Exit responsibilities

Before the last working day, employees should complete a reasonable handover, return company property, transfer work records to approved repositories, submit outstanding expenses, and cooperate with access-removal procedures. Confidentiality and other continuing obligations remain applicable after departure as stated in relevant agreements.

21. Policy Directory and Employee Acknowledgement

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Where to get help

Routine policy questions may be directed to the employee's manager or People Operations. Security concerns should be reported through the designated security process, payroll questions through the payroll contact, and technology issues through IT support. Employees should use official channels rather than relying on informal messages when an issue requires an authoritative decision.

Policy updates

The company may revise this handbook from time to time. Material updates should be communicated through an appropriate company channel. Employees are responsible for reviewing communicated changes and asking questions when an updated requirement is unclear.

Acknowledgement

By acknowledging receipt of the handbook, an employee confirms that they have been given access to the policies and understand their responsibility to review and follow applicable requirements. Acknowledgement does not convert the handbook into a fixed-term employment contract and does not prevent lawful policy changes.

Training corpus notice

This handbook, Northstar Digital Solutions Pvt. Ltd., its policies, examples, names, and monetary figures are fictional and were created solely as a synthetic corpus for a LangChain engineering capstone. They must not be presented as the policies of a real employer. The document is intentionally detailed so that retrieval, citations, refusal behavior, evaluation, streaming, and agent-tool selection can be tested against a stable PDF corpus.